

## Chapter 5: Study Skills

NSHS is dedicated to achieving excellence in medical education, and as part of this commitment, it has incorporated study skills into its curriculum to create a more conducive learning environment for students. These study skills offer a comprehensive approach to effective learning. Let's delve into these strategies in more detail:

### Best Study Practices

Make sure you are processing the information as deeply as possible by using the following strategies:

- ☐ Know the difference between familiarity (“Oh yeah, I remember reading that.”) and recall (“I can recall that information without looking.”)
- ☐ Think about how you prove to yourself that you know something – do you have to say it out loud? Re-draw a chart? Explain it to someone else?
- ☐ The more times you see it and think about it in a slightly different way, the deeper you are processing. Pre-reading before a lecture and review/ organization after a lecture are very helpful.
- ☐ Use elaboration to help you remember. Link the information to what you already know and make it meaningful.
  - Reorganize the information using charts, outlines, or diagrams.
  - Use vivid visualization.
  - Act out a situation by using the roleplay strategy.
- ☐ Organize your studying by layering. Learn the major, overarching concepts first. Then learn the big categories under those major concepts. Follow up with the major headings, sub-headings, etc. Learn successively smaller layers of details as you have time.
- ☐ Use practice exams/questions from study aids to help guide your studying.
- ☐ Conceptual understanding rather than cramming is important – there is no major secret to learning other than **TIME** and **REPETITION**.

### Reading

- ☐ Take care with highlighting. Rather than highlighting as you read, which can easily become mindless, highlight after you have finished a paragraph or section. Take a minute to think about the most important information and go back to highlight it.
- ☐ After finishing a section, think about some possible exam questions that might be asked about that section. Try to predict how the question might be worded, what the correct answer would be, and what misleading answers would be.

### Lectures

- ☐ **Prepare in advance to get the most out of lectures.**
- ☐ Pre-read by looking over the major concepts. Pre-reading should involve a basic skimming of the material and take about 10-15 minutes.
- ☐ Try to get a basic understanding of new words/ideas.

- ☐ Think about what might be most difficult to understand in lecture and where you will really need to pay attention.
- ☐ Go through the learning objectives in the relevant study guides.
- ☐ How will notes be organized? Will you try to write everything down or try to pull out only the most important information?
- ☐ Sit where distractions will be minimized (e.g., looking at what others are doing; temptation to check email).
- ☐ If you are not feeling focused or find a section difficult to understand, make sure to note where you stopped paying attention so you can go back to it later.
- ☐ Briefly review lecture notes & books within a day or two, mark what was clear and what needs clarification. Lecture notes are not the replacement of books.
- ☐ Reorganize, restate, reformat – this will help you process at a deeper level.
- ☐ Integrate/cross-reference notes with previous lectures, books, other study aids.
- ☐ Think about your own personal learning style – do you get more out of lecture if you read beforehand, or do you get more out of reading if you hear the lecture first?

## **Study Atmosphere**

- ☐ Know where you learn best.
- ☐ Do you need absolute silence or a bit of noise?
- ☐ Do you need to go somewhere or is studying in your room best? Should you go to same place every day or does variety help?
- ☐ Do you focus best sitting at a desk? On the couch? Walking around a room? Writing on a large white board? Try not to use your bed for studying so you can connect it only with relaxation.

## **Combined/ Group Study**

- ☐ Be thoughtful about whether you are the kind of person who studies better with others, and if so, whom those people might be. Your best friend is not necessarily your best study partner. In fact, studying with someone who is quite different from you may yield better results because you will be getting a new perspective.
- ☐ Agree on the goals and norms of the partnership or group.
- ☐ How much preparation is necessary? Are you learning together or are you testing each other?
- ☐ How will time be spent? Will you actually be going over material together, or do you just need an accountability partner to check in with, but you do not actually want to talk?
- ☐ Check in periodically to make sure the partnership/group is still working for everyone.

## **Know When You Need a Break**

- ☐ How often do you need to take a break? Make sure that a break is really a break. Get up, go outside, walk around.
- ☐ Keep track of when you get hungry and what you need to eat to give you an energy boost so you can plan ahead with snacks and meal breaks.

- ☐ Note your caffeine intake. When do you need it the most? What is the ideal amount that keeps you alert, but not jittery? At what time of day do you need to stop drinking caffeine so you can fall asleep easily?

### **Plan for Difficulty in Focusing**

- ☐ Know what type of studying is best at different times of day. For example, if you are a morning person, study the hardest material in the morning and keep the evenings for tasks that do not require a lot of attention, but will prepare you for the following day, such as making flashcards or rewriting charts.
- ☐ Have strategies to ease yourself into studying when you just do not feel like it or cannot focus. For example, if you cannot focus on reading, do not just sit there, stare at the book, and mentally beat yourself up. Do something that is a bit easier or more enjoyable for you (in terms of study activity and/or content) and then try again in 30 minutes.

### **Understand Your Learning Style(s)**

Some examples:

- ☐ Visual/graphic
- ☐ Kinaesthetic / movement
- ☐ Auditory
- ☐ Interpersonal
- ☐ Reading / writing

Understanding your learning style will help you adapt to strategies that will effectively guide your learning. If you are concerned about mastering the material, don't hesitate to ask for help. Ask early and ask often! Ask a variety of people for advice, and then follow what suits your needs. Year In-charges, Block Coordinators, Module coordinators, classmates, colleagues, professional mentors, and, of course, Department of Medical Education, are great resources.

### **Resource Websites:**

- ☐ <http://medicalmnemonics4u.blogspot.com>
- ☐ <https://sabkuchonline.pk/>